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FEATURES

The stories that stay: What remains when memory fades

TED Staff · TED Blog

By Brigid Jacoby, with Amanda Lynch

November is National Alzheimer's Awareness Month, a time to pause, reflect and continue the conversation on a disease that touches millions of lives around the world. Alzheimer's isn't just a medical challenge — it's an emotional one that reshapes families, identities and the way we connect with one another.

Every TED Talk begins with a story. Every story begins with a memory. That is the idea at the heart of the TED Memory Project, created in partnership with Eli Lilly and Company. It's a multi-platform, multi-month movement that explores how memory drives innovation and connection while advancing understanding and empathy around Alzheimer's.

In his TED Talk, "Where does your sense of self come from? A scientific look," Anil Ananthaswamy shares: "Take, for instance, the question 'Who am I?' The most likely answer you will get or give to such a question will be in the form of a story. We tell others, and indeed ourselves, stories about who we are. We take our stories to be sacrosanct. We are our stories. But a condition that most of us, sadly, will be familiar with, Alzheimer's disease, tells us something quite different. Alzheimer's begins by affecting short-term memory. Think about what that does to someone's story. In order for our stories to form, to grow, something that just happens to us has to first enter short-term memory and then get incorporated into what is called long-term episodic memory. It has to become an episode in our narrative."

This blog is one way of continuing that work, giving space for voices like Brigid Jacoby's to reflect on how Alzheimer's can alter identity and the stories that shape us. It is a space for reflection, where ideas meet lived experience, and where the threads of resilience, grief, curiosity and hope come into focus.

When Brigid watched Anil's TED Talk, one idea struck her: our sense of self is built on the stories we tell about our past, our families and the choices we have made. Alzheimer's complicates this deeply because it disrupts short-term memory, the very building blocks of those stories. Without being able to record and recall, the narrative of who we are becomes harder to sustain. "That idea resonated with me because I have seen firsthand how Alzheimer's can change a person's sense of self, not by erasing them, but by reshaping how their identity is expressed," Brigid said.

Brigid shares her reflections after the recent passing of her mother, Anne, who lived with early-onset Alzheimer's. Anne passed on October 30th, 2025, early in the morning, surrounded by her three children. She began experiencing symptoms in her late forties, with her first memory complaints documented at 51. At first, it was small things like misplacing her keys, forgetting dates or struggling with her computer. But soon, the disease began interfering with her

work. After more than 20 years in her industry, she lost her job, and even retail shifts became difficult when she couldn't navigate the digital sales system. Brigid's younger sibling even took a job at the same shop just to help keep an eye on her.

Anne was a storyteller. As an Irish American, she carried forward the histories of her grandparents immigrating from Ireland, weaving them into a family tapestry she often shared with her children. Her sense of self was tied to these stories and to the act of passing them down.

"One day, sitting outside with my mom, I asked her to retell a story about my great-grandmother," Brigid recalls. "But this time, I watched panic rise in her eyes as she struggled to understand what I was referencing. The words did not come. Instead, tears did. It was not just memory loss, it was a fracture in identity, the vanishing of a thread she had long held onto as proof of who she was and where she came from."

Over time, Brigid and her siblings learned to meet Anne in a different place, one not rooted in lost stories but in new ways of being together. They leaned into humor, curiosity and wonder. They asked silly questions, marveled with her at the shape of plants and clouds, or let her imagination spin freely without the pressure of accuracy. In those moments, Anne still expressed herself. Not through the precise retelling of family history, but through joy, silliness and awe.

Anil's TED Talk reminded Brigid that even as memory fades, the self is not gone — it is simply altered. As Ananthaswamy explains, "I also believe that altered selves should not be seen as the outcome of deficits, or as the outcome of a lack of attributes considered normal. They are different ways of being, and it is the willingness of some of us to confront the self's constructed nature that is helping make sense of the self for all of us."

That is why Alzheimer's awareness matters to her. She wants people to understand that while the disease changes a person, it does not erase them, a lesson she carries forward after her mother's recent passing. "This awareness gives us tools to show up differently," Brigid said. "To support loved ones as they move into a new version of themselves, rather than turning away in fear or discomfort. My hope is that people can approach those living with Alzheimer's with patience, curiosity and care, seeking to understand what they are experiencing instead of mourning only what has been lost. By doing so, we can honor who they are becoming, not just who they were."

Because behind every statistic is a person like Anne, whose story Brigid now carries forward. And behind every talk is someone like Brigid, reminding us why these conversations must continue.

India Bihar Location Map

landofmaps · Land of Maps

Bihar is a state in northeastern India.

The India Bihar Location Map showcases the geographical location of Bihar within India.

Bihar is known for its rich history, cultural heritage, and contributions to ancient and modern India.

The state is home to various important religious sites and historical landmarks.

Exploring Bihar through the India Bihar Location Map can provide valuable insights into its geographical significance.

Bihar has a long and illustrious history that dates back to ancient times. It has witnessed the rise and fall of several empires and has played a pivotal role in shaping India's cultural and intellectual heritage. The ancient kingdom of Magadha, centered around modern Bihar, was one of the first major Mahajanapadas (republics) in ancient India.

During the Mauryan Empire (322 BCE – 185 BCE), Bihar reached its zenith of political and cultural importance. It was the capital region of the empire under the reign of Emperor Ashoka, who famously embraced Buddhism after the bloody Kalinga War.

Over the centuries, Bihar saw the rule of various dynasties, including the Guptas, Palas, and the Bihar Shahi dynasty. The region has also been a significant center for learning, with the ancient Nalanda University attracting students from all over the world.

In more recent history, Bihar played a crucial role in India's independence movement, with prominent leaders like Mahatma Gandhi, Rajendra Prasad, and Jayaprakash Narayan emerging from the state.

Bihar is home to the famous Bodh Gaya, the place where Gautama Buddha attained enlightenment.

The state is known for its vibrant festivals, including Chhath Puja, which is dedicated to the Sun God.

Bihar is characterized by diverse geographical features, including the fertile Gangetic plains in the north and the Chota Nagpur Plateau in the south.

The Gandhi Setu, also known as the Ganga Bridge, connects Patna (the capital of Bihar) to Hajipur and is one of the longest river bridges in India.

The state is renowned for its Madhubani paintings, a traditional art form that originated in Bihar and showcases intricate patterns and vibrant colors.

Bihar has significant archaeological sites, such as Rajgir, where ancient ruins and Buddhist stupas can be explored.

Relevant Facts about Bihar

Year Event

1950 BCE Magadh kingdom was established, laying the foundation of ancient Bihar.

6th Century BCE Gautama Buddha attained enlightenment at Bodh Gaya in Bihar.

4th Century BCE Nalanda University, one of the world's first residential universities, was founded in Bihar.

3rd Century BCE Ashoka the Great embraced Buddhism after the Kalinga War and erected numerous pillars with his edicts across Bihar.

1540 CE Sher Shah Suri, a prominent ruler, established the Sur Empire with Bihar as its capital.

1947 CE India gained independence from British rule, with Bihar becoming a part of the newly-formed Indian republic.

1. What is the importance of Bihar in Indian history?

Bihar has played a critical role in Indian history, witnessing the rise and fall of ancient empires, hosting renowned centers of learning, and being a catalyst for India's independence movement.

2. Where is Bihar located in India?

Bihar is situated in the eastern part of India, bordering Nepal and various Indian states like Uttar Pradesh and West Bengal.

3. What are the major attractions in Bihar?

Bihar is home to several important attractions, including historic sites like Bodh Gaya, Nalanda University, Rajgir, and religious sites like Mahabodhi Temple and Patna Sahib Gurudwara.

4. Are there any famous festivals celebrated in Bihar?

Yes, Bihar celebrates several vibrant festivals, with Chhath Puja being one of the most notable ones, dedicated to the Sun God.

5. What is unique about Bihar's cultural heritage?

Bihar's cultural heritage is enriched with various art forms like Madhubani painting, Manjusha art, and folk dances like Jat-Jatin and Jhumar.

6. What is the best time to visit Bihar?

The winter season (October to February) is generally considered the best time to visit Bihar, as the weather is pleasant for exploring the historical and natural attractions.

7. How can I reach Bihar?

Bihar is well-connected by air, rail, and road. The state has several airports, and major cities like Patna have railway

Equity Allocation in Startups

Scott Johnson (fuzzyblog)

Once upon a time, I was speaking with a company founder and they mentioned that they had a VP of Engineering to whom they have given a 1/3 stake in the company. I immediately commented that was too much and then said “I’ll write this down in a blog post” – and then I never did. Last night, oddly, I woke up from a deep sleep with the desire to write this down. And that brings us to this post.

Here’s what I can remember from that conversation:

Company Stage : Pre Funding

Company Type : Medical

Equity Split with the VP of Engineering : 1/3

Founder Title : Yes

Did VP of Engineering Put in Cash : No

You Need to Understand This

One of the basic rules of the startup world is that on Day 1, you, the founder, own 100% of something that is worth absolutely nothing . The goal, by the end, is that you own a much smaller percentage of something actually worth something. As an example, owning 10% of something worth \$10 million is actually much, much better.

The Basic Rules of Thumb for Equity Allocations

Here are my rules of thumb to use for equity allocation:

The more risk you take, the more you get

The earlier you join, the more you get

Putting time in is one type of risk

Putting cash in is a greater type of risk

If you, the founder, give too much equity to someone else then you can be pushed out by simply having that other person align with the investor or investors

You only have 80% of the equity to play with - 20% generally goes to an ESOP (employee stock option plan)

Make damn sure that you give out options not stock and a long vesting schedule (incremental over say 4 years)

The bottom line is that equity, in whatever form, is a reward for taking risk. And the earlier you are involved in a startup, the more risk there is.

My Personal Experience from Feedster

A long, long time ago, I founded a blog search engine named Feedster. I merged with another RSS search engine shortly

after coming to market to address some technical limitations in my architecture. We did the typical nerd founder thing and simply split the equity down the middle and both took the Founder title.

In retrospect that wasn’t a fair allocation because I committed significantly more time to Feedster but it avoided a difficult conversation that I was simply not brave enough to have – and that was a mistake.

Once we realized that blog search was actually a viable business, my first hire was a CEO to handle the operations and capital raise. This CEO:

Came in after the technology was built

Came in after the site had traffic

Came in after growth was proven

Did not have to put in any personal money

The equity allocation for that CEO, bear in mind that this was 16 years ago so my memory may be fuzzy was between 9% and 10%. That CEO’s advice to me is that if we filled other VP level slots, we’d be talking about between a 3% to 5% stake.

If you contrast these numbers with the 1/3 equity split mentioned above, it is considerably less and the reason was that an awful lot of the risk had already been addressed (functional technology, working product, site with traffic, no capital investment, etc).

There are two important disclaimers to understand here:

I am not a lawyer (IANAL) and my focus is always on making great technology NOT on the best personal economic return. This means that there are aspects of capital raising and equity allocation that I don’t now and likely never will fully understand.

I should also note that equity allocation is a particularly sensitive topic for me because, even though I was the founder, I was forced out by the people I hired and then voted off the board. And while I am over it (somewhat), had the equity allocations been handled differently, that might not have happened.

What Should This Founder Do?

My advice to this founder is to get Marc Randolph’s book, That Will Never Work , about the founding of Netflix and read pages 180 to 189. Marc Randolph was the founder of Netflix and the original CEO. In these pages, Reed Hastings not only told Marc that he needed to step down as CEO and be replaced by Reed but that he needed to give a substantial portion of his equity to Reed in order for that privilege.

After reading these pages, I think that the founder needs to talk with the VP of Engineering and negotiate the equity split down. the 1/3 is just too high. Once upon a time, I

An Annotated Startup History Bibliography

Scott Johnson (fuzzyblog)

I've been reading High Tech case studies now since the 80s – just after I entered the business. Bryan Cantrill from Oxide Computer's podcast inspired me to get all my books out and order them on a rough historical basis. I thought listing them here might be interesting to someone. All of these I've read and there are a ton of lessons for entrepreneurs here. I put rough notes next to some of them in bold after the author name in quotes.

2022-06-27 - Added book of the week

2022-06-26 - Cleaned my bookcase and looked for other books in this category and added entries for How Would You Move Mount Fuji (Microsoft category), Go To (Misc / Software Category), Building a Successful Software Business (Misc / Software Category), Side Hustles (Misc / Software Category), Facebook by Steven Levy (Web 2 category), Tim Cook (Apple Category), A Piece of the Computer Pie (IBM Category), In Search of Stupidity (Misc / Software Category), Crypto (Misc / Software Category), Smart and Gets Things Done (Software Category), The Effective Engineer (Misc / Software Category), Creativity Inc (Apple Category), The Chip (Intel Category), Lean In (Web 2 Category), No Such Thing as a Free Gift (Microsoft Category), The Phoenix Project (Misc / Software Category)

2022-06-26 - Added Sub Categories in the Apple Section

2022-06-26 - Added Sub Categories in the Web 2 Section

2022-06-23 - Started adding links, added books suggested on Twitter, Added Gaskins on PowerPoint History; fixed typos (how did I possibly misspell Torvalds; clearly was stupid yesterday)

2022-06-23 - Apologies for where an Audible audio book is linked instead of hard or paperback; Amazon is inconsistent with this

2022-06-23 - Added a bunch more notes from reading these.

Book of the Week

In Search of Stupidity: Over 20 Years of High Tech Marketing Disasters

View on Amazon

This is an absolute gem of a book. There is a lot of humor here but the best bits, the parts I underline, start on Page 308 where he outlines positioning for a software product. In an extremely telling bit of analysis, he opens the book by looking at software companies in 1984 and then 2001. Even though there were a number of companies both larger than Microsoft or approximately Microsoft's size, in 2001, the next runner up, Adobe, is 1/20th of Microsoft's size. This he attributes to Microsoft being the only company "that never made a fatal, stupid mistake". And, yes, Ashton-Tate

is part of the 1984 list. A bit dated but it is also timeless. Recommended

IBM / Mainframes / Super Computers

1,000 Dollars and an Idea by Sam Wly

Eniac by McCartney

A Piece of the Computer Pie

The Ultimate Entrepreneur by Glenn Rifkin and George Harrar; "A fantastic read. Cantrill argues in his podcast that DEC had too many people – and they did – but they grew up in an era where you made everything right down to the cases. That leads to an incredible number of people."

MIT

The Friendly Orange Glow by Brian Dear; "One of my absolute favorites; everything we do online today happened here first (and then in Lotus Notes by Ray Ozzie but thank the FSM that went away)"

Broken Genius by Joel Shurkin; "The first proof that brains doesn't equal ethics; this was followed by Patrick Naughton, Hans Reiser and one of the php core team members"

Note: A lot of our modern media tech comes out of Lucas intellectual heritage which is why this is here

Inside the Star Wars Empire

The PC Era

Almost Perfect by W. E. Pete Peterson

Open by Rod Canion; "I agree with Bryan Cantrill that this should have been titled Compatible"

Microsoft Secrets by Cusuman and Selby; "This was the book that talked about employees leaving the office for coffee or soda and how detrimental it was for concentration. At the company I was at when this came out, our founder read it on a plane and we had soda in the office the next day. Only time he ever read a book that benefited engineers; ISO 9000 quality for software was one of the bad book fall outs."

All You Really Need to Know in Business I Learned at Microsoft by Julie Bick

Gates by Stephen Mane and Paul Andrews

Show Stopper by G. Pascal Zachary; "Damn near perfect"

Apple / Jobs / Pixar / Next

Apple by Jim Carlton

iWoz by Steve Wozniak

iCon by Jeffrey Young and William Simon

The Moth

Throughline (NPR)

Vladimir Putin has been running Russia since 2000 when he was first elected as President. How did a former KGB officer make his way up to the top seat — was it political prowess or was he just the recipient of a lot of good fortune? In this episode, we dive into the life of Vladimir Putin and try to understand how he became Russia's new "tsar."

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James Baldwin's Shadow

Throughline (NPR)

James Baldwin believed that America has been lying to itself since its founding. He wrote, spoke, and thought incessantly about the societal issues that still exist today. As the United States continues to reckon with its history of systemic racism and police brutality, Eddie S. Glaude Jr. guides us through the meaning and purpose of James Baldwin's work and how his words can help us navigate the current moment.

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A History of Hamas

Throughline (NPR)

With peace talks once again underway between Israel and Hamas, and hopes again growing for a permanent ceasefire, we're bringing you our episode on the origins of Hamas: where it came from, how its influence grew, and what it represents. Next week, our episode on Benjamin Netanyahu and the rise of Israel's right wing. This episode first ran in November 2023.

We've done episodes on Hamas, Israel, Lebanon, Iran, and more. Find them all in our series, "The Cycle".

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NuShell - When /bin/bash curl installs fail

Scott Johnson (fuzzyblog)

I've liked the concept of NuShell since I first heard about it. I then liked it more when I discovered that Yehuda Katz was involved since I strongly believe in picking software based on the pedigree of the engineers involved (no I don't - yet - have engineer trading cards but I'm thinking about it).

Although I have NuShell running on my experimental system, I've held off on using it on my main box mostly due to concerns about the vast amounts of things that pipe crap to /bin/bash like this:

```
/bin/bash -c "$(curl -fsSL https://raw.githubusercontent.com/Homebrew/install/HEAD/uninstall.sh)"
```

```
/bin/bash -c "$(curl -fsSL https://raw.githubusercontent.com/Homebrew/install/HEAD/install.sh)"
```

```
/usr/bin/find "$(brew --prefix)/Caskroom/"*"/.metadata' -type f -name '*.rb' -print0 | /usr/bin/xargs -0 /usr/bin/perl -i -0pe 's/depends_on macos: \[.*?\\]\\gsm;s/depends_on macos: */g'
```

That's an uninstall script, an install script and a find command. I tried all of these tonight on NuShell and they all failed. An example of this is:

```
/Users/sjohnson/Sync/coding$ /bin/bash -c "$(curl -fsSL https://raw.githubusercontent.com/Homebrew/install/HEAD/install.sh)"
```

```
/bin/bash: #!/bin/bash: No such file or directory /Users/sjohnson/Sync/coding$
```

Note : For non NuShell users, you can tell its NuShell above by the greater than sign in the prompt.

And then it struck me - I can likely simply execute /bin/bash from within NuShell and THEN run whatever I need to in bash. I tried it and it worked perfectly. So if you have problems with things that don't work on NuShell, try spinning up a /bin/bash session. After you're done, type exit and you are back in NuShell.

Improving Your Podcast Audio Quality

Scott Johnson (fuzzyblog)

The quality of your recorded audio for an at home podcaster is a black art. Audio is a fundamentally analog process and Once upon a time, in the antediluvian ages of podcasting (2005 / 2006), I was a podcaster. And then, a decade later, my friend Nick Janetakis, a producer of online courses also taught me a bunch of things about audio quality.

Here's one thing to know:

You will tell yourself that you can clean up the audio later. This will ALMOST NEVER happen. Getting the audio right at record time is key.

Here are some tips:

A good mic . I use A Yeti Blue USB for about \$149 and that's more than good enough.

A pop filter . This is a cheap (\$10) foam filter that goes in front of your mic and reduces mouth / breath noise.

Put a towel under your laptop . Laptops have fans and fans are mechanical and vibrate. Also your movement on the keys / mouse will make noise. A towel under the laptop acts as a shock absorber for movement / vibration.

Put your phone into do not disturb mode . If you are an iPhone user then set it to Do Not Disturb. If you have overrides on this for say calls / texts from family then create a Really Do Not Disturb (or call it Podcasting) setting and do not have overrides.

Turn off all your phone alarms . Make sure they are off.

Leave your phone in the other room . This is the easiest one.

Get rid of your chair with casters / the ability to lean back . Chairs move. A mic will pick this up.

Experiment with different USB ports for your mic . Different ports may have different isolation levels from the underlying circuitry of the machine. You may have less electrical hum / cross talk when you plug it on the right (or the left).

Log out of all Instant Messaging tools on your laptop . Again you want to suppress notification noises.

Don't record in a room with hardwood floors . Audio reverberates far more than you would think.

Record in the clothes / coat closet . A closet with clothes in it is actually a very silent area and the clothes eliminate audio bouncing back on you from the walls / ceiling / floor.

US to pay TotalEnergies \$1 billion to stop developing offshore wind in US

John Timmer · Ars Technica OpenForum

On Monday, the Trump administration announced its newest approach to its goal of blocking the development of offshore wind: pay companies to walk away from lease sites they had paid for under the Biden administration. The Department of the Interior, which arranges leases of coastal sites for the development of wind farms, would end up returning about \$1 billion to France's TotalEnergies, which has promised both to invest that money in US-based fossil fuel projects and to not do any further offshore wind development in the US.

Rumors of the deal had begun circulating last week . The deal comes in the wake of the administration's repeated failures to block offshore wind projects after construction had started.

The deal would see TotalEnergies invest roughly \$1 billion in oil and natural gas projects in the US. Once those commitments are made, the US would pay the company that amount in return for its abandonment of two areas it had leased for offshore wind. One of those areas would have hosted a relatively small project near the Carolinas. But the second project, Attentive Energy , is a large site east of New Jersey that would have the capacity to generate 3 Gigawatts of power—capacity that the nearby states would find difficult to replace with other means.

[Read full article](#)

Edward Said and the Question of Palestine

Throughline (NPR)

Edward Said brought the question of Palestine into the American mainstream. He taught at Columbia University for nearly 40 years, and today, more than two decades after his death, pro-Palestine student protesters on that campus and others have invoked his name. Meanwhile, his interviews circulate on social media and his books are taught at universities around the world. On this episode: the story of the man who pushed for recognition of the Palestinian perspective, the pushback he faced, and the dangers he foresaw.

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The 4th Amendment: Search and Seizure

Throughline (NPR)

The Fourth Amendment is the part of the Bill of Rights that prohibits “unreasonable searches and seizures.” But — what’s unreasonable? That question has fueled a century’s worth of court rulings that have dramatically expanded the power of individual police officers in the U. S. Today on the show, how an amendment that was supposed to limit government power has ended up enabling it.

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The Rise of the Right Wing in Israel

Throughline (NPR)

For most of its early history, Israel was dominated by left-leaning, secular politicians. But today, the right is in power. Its politicians represent a movement that uses a religious framework to define Israel and its borders, and that has aggressively resisted a two-state solution with Palestinians. And its government – led by Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu — is waging a war in Gaza which, according to the Gaza Health Ministry, has killed over 30,000 people, many of them children. The government launched the war in response to the October 7th, 2023 Hamas-led attack that, according to Israeli authorities, killed over 1,200 Israelis with an additional 250 being taken hostage. This is not the first time that tension has erupted into violence. But the dominance of right-wing thinkers in Israeli politics is pivotal to how the war has unfolded. On today's episode: the story of Israel's rightward shift.

Correction: In a previous version of this episode, we said incorrectly that Benjamin Netanyahu was born in 1948. He was born in 1949.

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The Three Faces of Ataturk

Throughline (NPR)

“Authority, without any condition and reservation, belongs to the nation.” A military commander named Mustafa Kemal uttered these words in 1923, on the eve of the founding of the Republic of Turkey. He would later rename himself Ataturk, “Father of the Turks.” And he was outlining a vision for the future: a future where old empires were buried and new nations reigned supreme. That vision would resonate beyond the borders of the new Turkey, becoming a shining example for leaders around the world of how to build a single unified national identity — no matter the cost.

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This is not the first time that tension has erupted into violence.

Throughline (NPR)

Essential Technology for a Team Offsite

Scott Johnson (*fuzzyblog*)

I'm in the process of wrapping up a team offsite even though I was ostensibly the lead technologist present, I was not actually prepared in terms of bringing the right technology with me to facilitate the team's needs. The single worst omission was the lack of an HDMI cable without which, I saw three tech folk (me, other engineer #1, team coordinator) fail to be able to connect a Mac, an iPad and a Windows box to a Chrome Cast equipped TV.

Here is my list of the technical stuff I will never again be without for a team meeting:

A couple of USB sticks. Even today in the age of Google Drive and DropBox, USB sticks can still be more convenient

An Anker USB battery just in case

2 lightning cables, at least one of which is 6 foot like this Amazon cable

1 6' USB type C cable

1 USB 2 cable

1 power strip with USB ports

1 extension cord with USB ports

1 Verizon Mifi Hotspot able to share connectivity if WiFi fails

1 ChromeCast

1 6' HDMI Cable

1 USB Speaker like a Beats Pill

This is roughly enough technology to support a team offsite of 6 to 8 people (imho).

Note : I use a MacBook 2015 classic so I still have real ports. If you are using newer MacBooks then you likely need dongles as well.

Chaos

Throughline (*NPR*)

What happens when teenagers are shipwrecked on a deserted island? Can you find the fingerprint of God in warzones? Why was the concept of zero so revolutionary for humanity? A year into a pandemic that has completely upended the lives of people around the world, we look at how we cope with chaos, how we're primed to make order out of randomness, and why the stories we're taught to believe about our propensities for self-destruction may not actually be true.

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Scott Johnson (fuzzyblog)

Assessing the impact of human error factors on railway accident severity: Evidence from accident investigation reports in Korea

Jun Lee · PLOS ONE Feed

by Changhun Kim, Jun Lee

This study investigates the role of human error factors in shaping the severity of railway accidents. Using a structured coding scheme to transform qualitative accident investigation reports into quantitative variables, the analysis reveals that deficiencies in managerial oversight, shortcomings in maintenance practices, and failures in equipment and system reliability are consistently associated with higher accident costs. These findings underscore the organizational and technical dimensions of human error as critical factors linked to accident severity, rather than merely front line worker mistakes. At the modeling level, the explanatory variables collectively account for a meaningful portion of the variation in accident costs, indicating that such outcomes are not purely random but systematically related to underlying human and organizational conditions. By identifying the relative importance of managerial, maintenance, and equipment-related deficiencies, this study provides empirical evidence for prioritizing these factors in railway safety management. The results highlight the need to strengthen organizational accountability, improve maintenance regimes, and ensure the reliability of technical systems as essential strategies for mitigating high-consequence accidents. These insights contribute to a deeper understanding of the organizational and systemic correlates of accident severity and can inform targeted interventions aimed at enhancing overall railway safety.

Converting from MySQL to Postgres using NMIG

Scott Johnson (fuzzyblog)

Historically I've been a MySQL advocate but I've recently been quite impressed with Postgres. This leaves me in the position of needing to migrate several MySQL databases over to Postgres -or- run two database engines in production. And, clearly, it is far more desirable to run only a single production database server.

I recently found the NPM tool NMIG and used it to successfully convert a MySQL database over to Postgres quickly and easily - once I got past the initial installation process.

Installing and Using NMIG

Here's what you need to do to use NMIG.

Pro Tip 2 : Go into your source database before you start the conversion and do a count on any table with a large number of records. This gives you a checksum on the overall process (NMIG has great logs but I always prefer belt and suspenders when it comes to working with valuable data).

On your machine you need to have a version of NPM installed that is version 10 or later.

Git clone the NMIG repo to a directory on your computer.

Change into that directory.

Edit the file config/config.json and set the credentials for your source and target .

Make a directory named nmig_logs .

Run npm install to install all the dependencies.

Run npm run build to convert the code from TypeScript to JavaScript.

Run the process with a syntax like this: npm start - --conf-dir='/Users/sjohnson/Sync/coding/my_x_is_y/nmig/config' - logs-dir='/Users/sjohnson/Sync/coding/my_x_is_y/nmig/nmig_logs'

Note : Obviously you need to update your directories as needed.

Pro Tip 2 : Go into your target database after the conversion and do a count on the same table and compare the results with the above.

Updating to the Latest Ansible on Ubuntu

Scott Johnson (fuzzyblog)

One of the tricky bits about Ansible is that new features in the “language” always require the latest version of Ansible itself. And, while logical, this can easily bite you. Here’s an example:

```
TASK [deploy_hate-language-modeling_systemd_start : just
force systemd to re-execute itself (2.8 and above)]
*** fatal : [ aws_master2 ]: FAILED! => {"changed" :
false , "msg" : " Unsupported parameters for (systemd)
module: daemon_reexec Supported parameters include:
daemon_reload, enabled, masked, name, no_block, state,
user" } to retry, use : -limit @/home/ubuntu/ansible/
playbook_deploy_hate-language-modeling_master.retry
```

What that translates to is that Ansible itself doesn’t know how to use the parameter `daemon_reexec` . And when you’ve been using an Ansible feature successfully and then it doesn’t work on the server, that usually is a rock solid signal “update ansible”.

Here’s how to do this on Ubuntu:

```
sudo apt update
sudo apt install software-properties-common
sudo apt-add-repository -yes -update ppa:ansible/
ansible sudo apt install ansible
```

The Scent of History

Throughline (NPR)

What if we told you that the key to time travel has been right in front of our eyes this whole time? Well, it has: it’s in our noses. Today on the show, the science — and politics — of smell, and how it links our past and our present.

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How Bad Bunny took Puerto Rican independence mainstream

Throughline (NPR)

How Bad Bunny became the global voice of a generation in crisis — and what it means when resistance becomes profitable.

Guests :

Carina Del Valle Schorske , writer, translator and wannabe backup dancer. She wrote a New York Times Magazine profile about Bad Bunny you can read here .

Vanessa Díaz , professor of Chicano/a and Latino/a Studies at Loyola Marymount University. She's been teaching a Bad Bunny college course 2023 and is the co-creator of the Bad Bunny Syllabus Project. She is also the co-author of P FKN R: How Bad Bunny Became the Voice of Puerto Rican Resistance .

Jorell Meléndez-Badillo , professor of Puerto Rican, Caribbean and Latin American History at University of Wisconsin, Madison. He's the author of Puerto Rico: A National History. He is also the author of the history visualizers for Bad Bunny's DTMF album.

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When Zoom Is Too Heavy for Your Laptop Just Use Your Phone or iPad

Scott Johnson (fuzzyblog)

This one is short but sweet and, honestly, the bulk of it is right in the title. I'm a pretty hard core software developer and I've found that the Zoom video chat tool, which my team uses every single day, tends to be big, fat and slow – to such a degree that my MacBook crashes from time to time. You should note that I do run a 2015 MacBook Pro 13" so not the best machine by today's standards but still absolutely serviceable as a daily driver for most development chores.

It occurred to me recently that both my phone and my iPad are actually faster than my laptop so I fired up Zoom on them for a conference call and wow was it better. I was able to code through my team call and participate in the team video chat. While my phone worked perfectly well, it had a tendency to slide a bit leading me to break out my home made phone stand (no pic; since my phone is in it how can I take a pic; ask me personally if you care or want one). My iPad, however, since it has the keyboard case, works fantastically well for this tho.

I'm also starting to use my iPad as my "chat workstation" allowing me to more easily partition the myriad chat apps that we all seem to use concurrently and focus on development more while still participating in chats without getting lost in them.

Recommended .

Cinco de Mayo and the Rise of Modern Mexico (2022)

Throughline (NPR)

Does history have a border? That is the question at the heart of Cinco de Mayo, May 5th, a holiday that symbolizes Mexico's fight for autonomy, even as it's come to be associated with sales and cervezas and margaritas in the U. S. Cinco de Mayo is part of a much deeper story of two nations — Mexico and the U. S. — trying to define themselves at a time when old empires were crumbling and borders were in flux. A story that culminated in a revolution in Mexico that was at the forefront of a worldwide movement against predatory capitalism and foreign domination. So in this episode, we're going back to the first Cinco de Mayo and exploring how it helped shape the future on both sides of the border.

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Abortion Before Roe

Throughline (NPR)

Abortion wasn't always controversial. In fact, in colonial America it would have been considered a fairly common practice: a private decision made by women, and aided mostly by midwives. But in the mid-1800s, a small group of physicians set out to change that. Obstetrics was a new field, and they wanted it to be their domain—meaning, the domain of men and medicine. Led by a zealous young doctor named Horatio Storer, they launched a campaign to make abortion illegal in every state, spreading a potent cloud of moral righteousness and racial panic that one historian later called “the physicians’ crusade.” And so began the century of criminalization. This episode originally ran as *Before Roe: The Physicians’ Crusade*.

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Octavia Butler: Visionary Fiction

Throughline (NPR)

Measuring cerebral glucose metabolism by chemical exchange-sensitive spin-lock (CESL) MRI of 2-deoxy-D-glucose in rodents

Philipp Mergenthaler · PLOS ONE Feed

by Philipp Boehm-Sturm, Patrick Schuenke, Marco Foddis, Susanne Mueller, Stefan P. Koch, Daniel J. Beard, Paul Holloway, Amin Mottahedin, Leif Schröder, Alastair M. Buchan, Philipp Mergenthaler

Magnetic resonance imaging (MRI) of glucose metabolism shows significant potential for identifying disease biomarkers and monitoring therapeutic responses in neurological conditions. Here, we present a protocol utilizing chemical exchange-sensitive spin-lock (CESL) MRI with the glucose analogue 2-deoxy-D-glucose (2DG) in the rat brain. We employed this method to characterize metabolic changes in ischemic tissue in a rat model of stroke. However, the utility of the technique is not limited to stroke and may be adapted to other disease models with minimal modifications. Previous research has demonstrated that CESL MRI is sensitive to various glucose analogs, including regular D-glucose, which is suitable for human application. Consequently, our protocol provides a foundation for a wide range of future applications in both basic and translational research, with potential utility in animal models and, eventually, human studies.

Polygraphs have major flaws. Are there better options?

Sarah Scoles, Undark Magazine · Ars Technica OpenForum

When George W. Maschke applied to work for the FBI in 1994, he had already held a security clearance for over 11 years. The government had deemed him trustworthy through his career in the Army. But soon, a machine and a man would not come to the same conclusion.

His application to be a special agent had passed initial muster. And so, in the spring of 1995, according to his account, he found himself sitting across from an FBI polygraph examiner, answering questions about his life and loyalties.

He told the truth, he said in an interview with Undark. But in a blog post on his website, he recalled the examiner told him that the polygraph machine—which measured some of Maschke's physiological responses—indicated that he was being deceptive about keeping classified information secret, and about his contacts with foreign intelligence agencies.

[Read full article](#)

All Wars Are Fought Twice

Throughline (NPR)

Octavia Butler’s alternate realities and ‘speculative fiction’ reveal striking, and often devastating parallels to the world we live in today. She was a deep observer of the human condition, perplexed and inspired by our propensity towards self-destruction. Butler was also fascinated by the cyclical nature of history, and often looked to the past when writing about the future. Along with her warnings is her message of hope - a hope conjured by centuries of survival and persistence. For every society that perished in her books, came a story of rebuilding, of repair.

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The Spotted Owl

Throughline (NPR)

The story of how the Endangered Species Act went from unanimous passage under a Republican president to becoming a deeply partisan wedge. The act was passed to protect big, beloved animals like bald eagles and blue whales; no one thought it would apply to a motley, reclusive owl. In this episode from Oregon Public Broadcasting’s Timber Wars , a story about saving the last of America’s old growth forests and the push to roll back environmental protections.

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Meltdown

Throughline (NPR)

“All wars are fought twice, the first time on the battlefield, the second time in memory,” writes Pulitzer Prize-winning author Viet Thanh Nguyen. This week on Throughline, we want to pause the news cycle to think about not just how war is experienced or consumed, but how it’s remembered. A refugee from the Vietnam War, Nguyen calls himself a scholar of memory — someone who studies how we remember events of the past, both as people and as nations. As the world watches the war in Ukraine — and with the U. S. departure from Afghanistan still fresh — we speak with Nguyen about national memory, selective forgetting, and the refugee stories that might ultimately help us move forward.

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The Real Black Panthers

Throughline (NPR)

The Black Panther Party’s battles for social justice and economic equality are the centerpiece of the Oscar-nominated film ‘Judas and The Black Messiah.’ In 1968, FBI Director J. Edgar Hoover said the Black Panther Party “without question, represents the greatest threat to internal security of the country.” And with that declaration he used United States federal law enforcement to wage war on the group. But why did Hoover’s FBI target the Black Panther Party more severely than any other Black power organization? Historian Donna Murch says the answer lies in the Panthers’ political agenda and a strategy that challenged the very foundations of American society.

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In the early hours of March 28, 1979, a system malfunction began what would become the worst nuclear accident in American history. What ensued punctured the public's belief in the safety of nuclear energy and became an awful study in the consequences of communication breakdown during a crisis. This week, the fallout of who and what to trust when a catastrophic event occurs.

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ANALYSIS

IN BRIEF

Marlowe Starling, Quanta Magazine: The passage of the sun across the sky — dawn, day, dusk, night — drives the clock of life. Some species wake with the sun and sleep with the moon. Others do the opposite, and a few keep odd hours. These naturally driven, 24-hour biological cycles are known as circadian rhythms, and they do more than cue bedtime: They regulate hormones, metabolism, DNA repair, and more. When life falls out of sync...

Source

Scientific American, Scientific American: Cortical Labs says the stunt points toward a new kind of low-power computing—and perhaps a new way to study neurological drugs

Throughline (NPR), Throughline (NPR): A record number of Americans have died from opioid overdoses in recent years. But how did we get here? And is this the first time Americans have faced this crisis? The short answer: no. Three stories of opioids that have plagued Americans for more than 150 years.

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Scott Johnson (fuzzyblog), Scott Johnson (fuzzyblog):

Tonsky recently had a great post about 4K monitors, fonts and scaling. The magic in this article are his suggestions around how to set fonts on your OSX machine. Apparently Apple does not set the defaults correctly (and, I'm writing this on a brand new OSX box that is NOTABLY improved by following his directions). This is the kind of stuff that I'm going to need to refer back to hence this post. Discussion thread about this .

How to download and install the Consolas Font .

Scientific American, Scientific American: A major defense against everything space throws at us, Earth's magnetic field may even protect the moon from damaging galactic cosmic rays

Throughline (NPR), Throughline (NPR): In February, President Trump declared a national emergency at the US-Mexico border. Last year, he ordered thousands of National Guard troops to the border. Is this the first time an American president has responded with this level of force? In this week's episode, the history of militarization at the U. S.-Mexico border.

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Throughline (NPR), Throughline (NPR): Big Bird, politics, and the ABCs: how a television show made to represent New York City neighborhoods like Harlem and the Bronx became beloved by families around a divided country. This episode originally ran in 2022 as "Getting to Sesame Street."

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TED Staff, TED Blog: Can't make it to Atlanta for TEDNext? TED Live brings the minute-by-minute excitement from the TED Theater to your home, school or office. Be one of the first to experience talks from visionary speakers like music mogul Jermaine Dupri, ballerina & activist Misty Copeland, neurosurgeon & reporter Sanjay Gupta, financial educator Vivian Tu and so many more.

Get your TED Live pass to stream the unedited talks in real time starting November 9 , or later on with the on-demand archive.

Natalie Wolchover, Quanta Magazine: Fifty-eight years after it first appeared, string theory remains the most popular candidate for the "theory of everything," the unified mathematical framework for all matter and forces in the universe. This is much to the chagrin of its rather vocal critics. "String theory is not dead; it's undead and now walks around like a zombie eating people's brains," the former physicist Sabine Hossenfelder...

Source

Throughline (NPR), Throughline (NPR): "Race" is often used as a fundamental way to understand American history. But what if "caste" is the more appropriate lens? In conversation with Pulitzer Prize winner Isabel Wilkerson, we examine the hidden system that has shaped our country.

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*I love the diversity of the songs on this album, but how it all has a very strong
point of view throughout.*

Adventurous Kate

The Pioneer Mirror

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